

DA ONLY — EYES ONLY

CASE BRIEF — THE BOUDICA PACT

Region: Staffordshire, England / London / Rome / Birmingham

Case Duration: 7 days (columns 7 → 1)

Artifact: The Keystone Coin (Tier 2 — Threatening)

Sessions: 2-3

MYSTERY STATEMENT

"A Tier 2 binding — sustained by a single gold coin buried in a Staffordshire field since the 7th century — has been breached by a farmer who ploughed up the keystone and then vanished, and the agents must trace the pact from a Mercian monk's chronicle in London to a Roman ledger in the Vatican to a museum vault in Birmingham before the entity the coin was holding back finishes waking up."

THE REAL STORY

What the Binding Is

After Boudica's defeat in 61 CE, her dying curse was adopted by something older than the Celts — a presence in the earth that had no name, no form, no voice until she gave it one. It took her rage and made it eternal. The Romans called it "the Red Woman." It manifested as a creeping blight: crops withered, water soured, livestock starved in the womb. The Romans tried everything. In 78 CE, Agricola authorized a pact. Gold was buried at the blight's epicenter. As long as gold remained, the entity slept. The transaction was recorded in a ledger — dry, bureaucratic Latin, filed as an "exceptional expense." One copy went to Rome and was eventually archived in the Vatican. The Anglo-Saxons reinforced the binding in the 7th century with the Staffordshire Hoard. A Mercian monk named Eadwine recorded the reinforcement, between complaints about the food and his abbot.

What Happened

In 1984, archaeologists excavated most of the Staffordshire Hoard. They missed one coin — the keystone, deeper than their radar reached. In 1987, farmer Arthur Dunn's plough struck it. He showed it around the pub, vague about what he'd found. "Something interesting." He left for a fishing trip to Scotland. He has not returned. His cottage is locked. His post is piling up. Within 72 hours of the coin's removal, the blight began returning — locusts navigating to the farm, water turning briny, a spreading silence.

The Keystone Coin

The coin does not "activate" in the traditional sense. Its effect is passive and location-dependent. When buried in the earth at the binding locus (a specific point on Dunn's farm), the coin sustains a pact that keeps the bound entity dormant. When removed, the binding weakens. The coin itself is inert above ground — it is merely gold. The power is in the pact, not the object. The coin is a key. The lock is the earth. The door is the binding. Any

gold from the original binding will work — the pact specifies "gold, measured by weight." It does not specify a quantity. The Romans were precise about loopholes. A single coin is sufficient.

Key Structural Difference

The artifact (the keystone coin) is NOT what the agents recover. The coin was removed by the farmer, who is missing. The agents must acquire a REPLACEMENT coin from the Birmingham Museum to re-bury at the binding site. The museum coins are behind glass, in vaults, legally protected. The climax is a museum infiltration followed by a ritual re-burial.

RESOLUTION PATHS

Contain (Covenant Objective)

The agents acquire a replacement coin from the Birmingham Museum (any gold from the original hoard will work), bury it at the binding locus on Dunn's farm, and speak the binding words from either Eadwine's chronicle or the Roman ledger. The binding is restored. The blight recedes. The entity returns to dormancy. The Covenant establishes a long-term monitoring post at the locus. Standing order filed: reinforcement needed in 300-500 years.

Find the Farmer

Track Arthur Dunn and recover the original keystone coin. This path is harder — Dunn is genuinely missing, not hiding. His trail goes cold in Scotland. He's been circling Staffordshire at a 20-mile radius, unable to return, unable to leave. If found, the original coin creates a stronger binding than a replacement. But time is running out.

Witness and Report

The binding fails. The entity partially manifests. The blight spreads beyond Staffordshire — Birmingham, then London. The Thames turns to brine. Locusts blanket the Midlands. The Covenant files a containment failure report. The Decay track advances. This is a "case with a scar."

Catastrophe

The entity fully manifests. The "Red Woman" becomes visible — a heat-shimmer with a voice that predates human speech. The blight radius expands exponentially. Crops fail across England. The British government declares a state of emergency. The Covenant is exposed. The Decay track advances by 3.

DA CHECKLIST — BEFORE SESSION 1

TASK	DONE
Print Operations Board + Organization Reference	☐
Print Location Pages L1-L7	☐
Print NPC Cards NPC1-NPC8	☐
Print and cut Information Cards I1-I22	☐
Print Relic Sheet	☐
Give players Case Brief — Player	☐
Start clock: Day 7, Morning	☐

KEY DRAMATIC BEATS

1. **Day 7-6:** Agents arrive in Staffordshire. The farm is the epicenter. Dunn is missing. The pub has stories — conflicting, partial. Research ties the location to the Staffordshire Hoard. Soil analysis at the binding locus confirms gold residue and anomalous mineral content.
2. **Day 5:** Relic Milestone — the silence spreads. Birds stop singing within 3 miles. The British Library yields Eadwine's chronicle — references "the queen who would not leave" and "the book of reckonings in the iron-men's city of stone." I10, I11, I16 become available.
3. **Day 4-3:** Agents fly to Rome. The Vatican Archive has the ledger — but access takes time the agents don't have. Father Matteo, the archivist, is cooperative but bound by procedure. The ledger reveals the terms: gold in earth, binding holds. Gold removed, subject returns. No quantity specified — a single coin is sufficient. The Romans were precise about loopholes. O1M1 triggers: Dr. Price notices shifted displays.
4. **Day 2:** Return to England. The Birmingham Museum holds the hoard behind glass and in vaults. Dr. Helen Price, the curator, will not lend a coin. Mr. Okonkwo, the night guard, has seen the coins shift in their case after midnight. He'll help. The agents must infiltrate or negotiate. O1M2 triggers: Okonkwo becomes an ally.
5. **Day 1:** Relic Milestone — the voice. Someone very hungry, very far away, calling. The binding site on Dunn's farm. The ground is breathing. The blight radius is 10 miles. The agents bury the coin, speak the words. The binding holds — or it doesn't. O3M2 triggers: quarantine expands. The re-burial must be covert.

RUNNING THE MUSEUM VAULT SCENE

The Birmingham Museum has the hoard in two locations: the public gallery (coins in a glass display case, alarmed, cameras) and the secure vault (climate-controlled, motion-sensored, two locked doors). Agents can approach through:

- **Dr. Price (Manipulate Diff 3):** She's protective of the hoard. She doesn't believe in cursed coins. But she's a scientist — evidence might convince her. If agents can demonstrate the blight is real and connected to the hoard, she may allow supervised access.
- **Mr. Okonkwo (ally after O1M2):** He's seen the coins glow. He'll help — patrol schedules, security gaps, a 90-second window when the vault camera loops. He can't override security, but he knows when it's vulnerable.
- **Infiltration (Sneak + Tech, multiple rolls):** The vault is not impenetrable but it's not easy. Alarms, cameras, two locked doors, motion sensors. A coordinated team can get in. A failed attempt triggers police response and locks down the museum permanently.

RUNNING THE RE-BURIAL RITUAL

The climax at L7 (the binding locus). Requirements: a coin from the hoard, the binding words (from Eadwine's chronicle or the Roman ledger), and the will to stand at the threshold while something ancient resists being put back to sleep.

The ritual takes 10 minutes. The agent performing the burial pays +2 Corruption. If the binding words are spoken correctly and the coin is placed in the earth, the ground settles. The locusts disperse. The silence breaks into birdsong. The binding is restored.

If the ritual is attempted without the binding words, the ground rejects the coin (Fracture condition). The coin flies upward, glowing hot. The entity is partially present for 60 seconds — visible as a heat-shimmer, audible as fabric tearing, a voice in a language that predates human speech. Everyone at the locus takes +3 Corruption.

The coin can be retrieved and the ritual attempted again, but the Artifact Die resets to d4 — the coin is nearly spent.